10 CHALLENGES IN GLOBAL AI GOVERNANCE

Cole Jackson, Lead Associate, BRICS+ Consulting Group, Alumni, Southern Africa-Netherlands Cyber Security School (SANCS)

1 Regulatory Fragmentation

The lack of a unified global framework for AI regulation has led to fragmented rules across regions, from the EU's AI Act to China's algorithmic oversight laws. This divergence hinders international cooperation and complicates compliance for global tech firms. A potential solution lies in developing shared principles through multilateral forums such as the UN or OECD to harmonise governance standards.

2 Ethical and Cultural Divergence

Ethical values around privacy, autonomy, and human oversight differ sharply between societies. For instance, facial recognition may be acceptable for security in one country but a privacy violation in another. Establishing cross-cultural dialogues and adaptable ethical frameworks could help balance respect for local norms with global human rights.

3 Data Sovereignty and Access

Nations are increasingly asserting control over data generated within their borders, as seen in India's data localisation policies. This raises tensions between open data sharing for innovation and protecting national interests. Cooperative data trusts and regional agreements could help ensure equitable access while safeguarding privacy and sovereignty.

4 Algorithmic Transparency

AI systems often operate as 'black boxes', making their decisions difficult to interpret or challenge. In sectors like finance or healthcare, this opacity can have serious consequences. Mandating explainability standards and open auditing protocols could foster trust and accountability in critical AI applications.

5 Accountability Gaps

When an autonomous vehicle or AI trading system causes harm, assigning responsibility remains complex. Legal systems are still grappling with who should be held liable — the developer, operator, or user. Establishing clear liability frameworks and AI insurance mechanisms could bridge this accountability void.

6 Security and Weaponisation Risks

AI is rapidly being integrated into military and cyber systems, raising fears of autonomous weapons and large-scale misinformation. The use of AI in drone warfare, for example, has already blurred ethical boundaries. International treaties, similar to those for nuclear or biological weapons, could set limits on AI's military deployment.

7 Economic Displacement

Automation driven by AI threatens millions of jobs worldwide, especially in manufacturing and services. For instance, AI chatbots are replacing customer service roles at scale. Governments and corporations must invest in reskilling programmes and inclusive innovation strategies to ensure that the benefits of AI are broadly shared.

8 Concentration of Power

A handful of corporations dominate AI research, cloud infrastructure, and data ownership — mostly based in the United States and China. This imbalance risks marginalising smaller nations and firms. Encouraging open-source AI models and fostering regional innovation hubs could democratise access to AI technology.

9 Bias and Discrimination

AI systems trained on skewed datasets can perpetuate gender, racial, or socioeconomic bias — seen in recruitment algorithms or facial recognition tools that misidentify minorities. Transparent data governance and diverse design teams are essential to correct systemic inequities.

10 Lack of Global Coordination

AI governance efforts are scattered across different institutions and agendas, from UNESCO to the G7. The absence of a cohesive global body limits progress on ethical and safety standards. Establishing a dedicated Global AI Governance Council under the UN or similar platform could unify and guide international efforts.